

EYEWITNESS January–March 1968

Siege of Khe Sanh

As part of the Tet Offensive, the North Vietnamese Army subjected the isolated Marine base of Khe Sanh to daily shelling for six weeks. Sometimes there was little that the besieged Marines could do but hunker down in their sandbag bunkers and hope that the US bombing campaign to repel the NVA would eventually prevail.

Outside the bunkers, Marines filling sandbags were caught by the first shell burst, and exploding rockets sent showers of hot fragments everywhere. Meanwhile, inside the bunkers the marines tried to make themselves as small as possible by hugging their legs and bowing their heads. As the tempo of the shelling increased, in their minds the small opening to the bunker seemed to grow and the 6,000 sandbags over the bunker seemed dangerously thin.

When the shells stopped, a few men climbed out of the bunker and checked if more dead or wounded men were outside. Medics rushed through the area. Inside the bunker, the marines resumed what they were doing: one continued to play the guitar, two men picked up their card game where they had left it, and another went back to his paperback book.

“The shelling wasn’t worth discussing.”

ASSOCIATED PRESS CORRESPONDENT JOHN T. WHEELER, DISPATCH FILED FROM KHE SANH, FEBRUARY 12, 1968